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"Larger than Bosnia": Explaining Clinton's First Balkan Gambit

Introduction

This paper examines potential explanations for Clinton's intervention in the Bosnian War and argues which factor was most crucial in his decision making. Some scholars attribute Clinton's involvement to the moral responsibility he felt regarding the ongoing atrocities which were inflamed by graphic footage of violence broadcast across news networks. Others explain Clinton's decision through domestic political pressures surrounding his reelection campaign. A third school of thought argues that Clinton intervened to preserve US leadership and safeguard its alliances. This paper argues that the third argument is the most plausible explanation for his intervention.

Background

The anti-interventionist camp believed that military action in Bosnia was operationally unfeasible. Early in the administration National Security Advisor Anthony Lake advised Clinton to take a passive approach because "There's not much we can do about Bosnia".[i] The tactical challenges of navigating forested and mountainous terrain would endanger US forces and enable continuous guerrilla activity.[ii] This meant that the US would require more troops if it chose to intervene.[iii] Additionally, the intermingled nature of Muslim, Serb and Croat populations made it difficult to separate warring factions.[iv] These ethnic groups lived side by side and were integrated in communities like a patchwork quilt. [v] This

increased the risk that civilians could get caught in the crossfire of war.[vi] Clinton referred to Bosnia as a "hopeless swamp from which the United States should stay far away".[vii]

This camp believed that intervening would have high costs for the US military. In his first year Clinton was constantly turned off from intervention due to high predictions of military commitment.[viii] Powell believed that little could be done without an overwhelming commitment of ground troops[ix] which he estimated at 100,000 soldiers.[x] Powell also noted that the resolve of the Serbs was incredibly strong and that they would bear risks that endangered US troops.[xi] Bush's Deputy Secretary of State Eagleburger witnessed the Serb's use of force first hand, and reported back that "It is going to be bloody as hell".[xii] Albright disagreed with the high troop estimates and argued that limited military operations could be conducted successfully.[xiii] She attributed Powell's expectations to an "overlearning" of the lessons of Vietnam.[xiv] As Clinton's cabinet moved towards intervention they placed their trust in a flexible combination of military and diplomatic coercion that relied heavily on airpower rather than a massive ground deployment.[xv]

The interventionists viewed the conflict in a clear-cut "good versus evil" paradigm. Clinton entered office hawkish on intervention, designating the Serbs as aggressors and the Muslims as "good guys".[xvi] Elie Wiesel, Holocaust survivor and advocate of Bosnian intervention, told the president that he could not sleep after witnessing the horrors in Bosnia.[xvii] The fall of Srebrenica elicited emotional reactions from much of Clinton's staff; Vice President Gore directly confronted the president's decision to be passive during such an atrocity.[xviii]

The non-interventionists believed that the conflict demanded a more nuanced interpretation than "good versus evil". Particularly during the early days of the war non-interventionists explicitly described the fighting as two-sided; Dick Cheney insisted during an interview that "This is an internal civil war".[xix] State Department spokesperson Richard Boucher acknowledged the existence of Serbian detention camps while suggesting that the Bosnian Muslims also maintained such facilities. [xx] He emphasized the complexities of the war and its roots in ancient ethnic tensions.[xxi] Powell penned an op-ed in *The New York Times* describing that the conflict held "deep ethnic and religious roots that go back a thousand years".[xxii] Acting Secretary of State Eagleburger characterized the conflict as "a civil war based in 500 to 1000 years of history". Clinton's Secretary of Defense Les Aspin suggested that Bosnian Muslims were also guilty of ethnic cleansing, remarking that "It's easy to analogize the Holocaust, but I never heard of any genocide by the Jews against the German people".[xxiii]

The non-interventionists maintained that military action should be reserved for protecting national interests. Powell was averse to any commitment that did not support vital security interests or that lacked a clear objective.[xxiv] Regardless of a conflict's impact on American prestige, Powell strongly believed that lives should not be lost to provide a "symbol" or a US presence.[xxv] Bush's Secretary of State James Baker echoed this sentiment, famously remarking that the US did not "have a dog in this fight" in Bosnia since the situation did not impact the country's security.[xxvi] Responding to calls for intervention, Bush made clear that while the US sought to provide humanitarian aid it was not committed to establish a lasting peace to Bosnia.[xxvii]

In contrast the interventionists believed in a broader mandate for the use of force which included the prevention of atrocities overseas. Senator Bob Dole was an early advocate for military action in Bosnia, motivated by the human rights abuses of Serbian forces.[xxviii] He made an emotional argument that the US had a moral obligation to end ethnic cleansing overseas.[xxix] In Elie Wiesel's appeal to Clinton, Wiesel stated that the US "must do something to stop the bloodshed in that country".[xxx] Clinton himself agreed that the US had a "unique responsibility" to stop inhumanity overseas and redeem the deaths that the country was unable or unwilling to save during the Holocaust.[xxxi] Albright also sympathized with the Bosnian Muslims and pushed for intervention.[xxxii] In a heated exchange with Powell she asked him "What are you saving this superb military for, Colin, if we cannot use it?'".[xxxiii]

Hypotheses

Some scholars explain Clinton's intervention in Bosnia through a moral responsibility to stop humanitarian abuses by the Serbs. Eric Szandzik argues in *World Affairs* that Clinton's action was rooted in a longterm belief that the Serbs were the conflict's aggressors and that the Muslim population deserved US support.[xxxiv] Throughout the campaign trail and his first term Clinton emphasized the need to prevent ethnic cleansing in Bosnia.[xxxv] The fall of Srebrenica in 1995 underscored the severity of humanitarian conditions as the news broadcast stories of rape, mass genocide and refugee crises.[xxxvi] Evidence suggests that at this time Clinton began to regret his non-intervention during the Rwandan Genocide which

further strengthened his resolve to help in Bosnia.[xxxvii] These moral motivations coincided with operational feasibility in summer 1995 and prompted Clinton to act.[xxxviii]

A second school of thought attributes Clinton's decision to domestic political motivations in advance of the 1996 election. Benjamin Schmidt writes in *YJIS* that "pursuing an end to the Bosnia conflict with the use of force was predicated on assuaging the concerns of a wary domestic political base".[xxxix] Clinton was aware that his early 'Containment' policy in Bosnia was reputationally disastrous; Lake blatantly told him that it was a cancer on the administration's foreign policy agenda.[xl] As the election loomed Clinton was advised that decisive action in Bosnia was required to avoid the appearance of incompetent leadership.[xli] As massacres in Srebrenica and Zepa were broadcast widely in summer 1995, Clinton did not want his failure in Bosnia to be a focal point of the campaign.[xlii] Meanwhile Senator and Republican nominee Bob Dole was pursuing an arms embargo lift that – if successful – would give him credit for victory in Bosnia.[xliii] Therefore, Clinton reasoned, decisive military action could remedy the situation.

A third explanation proposes that Clinton intervened in Bosnia to protect US leadership and safeguard its alliances. Gearóid Tuathail asserts in *Society and Space* that Bosnia held strategic significance for the US to manage its alliances dynamics.[xliv] Originally, the war was a question of European stability.[xlv] It soon became a test of diplomacy and UN peacekeeping.[xlvi] This was intrinsically tied to the cooperative security managed through NATO, putting the alliance's credibility at stake.[xlvii] US foreign policy leaders were forced to recognize Bosnia as a test of their institutions and a test of the US as a global leader in the

post-Cold War Era.[xlviii] The next section argues that this thesis most plausibly explains Clinton's decision.

Analysis

After years of humanitarian violations, Clinton only approved military intervention once alliance dynamics forced him into a corner. During his first three years in office the war in Bosnia featured systematic ethnic cleansing, random shelling of cities, targeting of women and children, rape, pillage and general destruction.[xlix] Despite the horrors Clinton had settled on a passive strategy of containment[l] which left responsibility to NATO and the UN to employ minimal defensive force.[li] Change only began on June 14th 1994, when Clinton's advisors informed him that NATO plan 40-104 would soon require him to send 20,000 troops to facilitate the impending withdrawal of UN peacekeeping troops; this commitment was previously unbeknownst to Clinton, who planned to make a decision on this issue "when the time [came]".[lii] Thus 40-104 necessitated some strategic action: Clinton needed to place troops in Bosnia or renege on his commitment to NATO.[liii] Reneging would risk NATO's destruction; this would be unthinkable since NATO was the most important alliance in the post-World War II period[liv] and a major lever in Clinton's "Democratic Enlargement" agenda.[lv] The administration realized that one way or another American troops would be on the ground.[lvi] The question now remained if those troops would passively witness the failed UN mission and provide support for their retreat or take an active approach to confront the Serbs.[lvii] While Clinton thought intensely searching for a remedy, Lake began drafting his own solution: an "Endgame Strategy" that would combine military force and

diplomacy.[lviii] Clinton showed immediate interest and would soon approve a formalized version of the plan.[lix]

Lake's Endgame Strategy satisfied Clinton's commitment to NATO but came with a political cost even in the event of success. His plan demanded that the United States conduct an aggressive bombing campaign to pressure the Serbs towards a diplomatic solution and offer NATO allies the ability to join the campaign. [lx] While pitching the plan Lake asked Clinton to "Tell me if you don't want to do this, stop me now because the risks are very clear.".[lxi] On one hand, a failure would be an embarrassment on the international stage.[lxii] Meanwhile a success would require 20,000 troops deployed in Bosnia to enforce a peace agreement between the Muslims and Serbs a year prior to Clinton's reelection campaign.[lxiii] Polls showed that Americans were dead set against the deployment of troops.[lxiv] Nonetheless Clinton agreed to the strategy with more resolution than Lake had ever seen of him.[lxv] Meeting with his advisors, Clinton told Lake to keep quiet to the media: "don't say we have a plan" he encouraged, as the group agreed that the plan would be difficult to sell.[lxvi]

Furthermore, Clinton's frustrations with Bosnia were not directed towards his own political viability but rather the lack of American control in the conflict. In May 1995 UN peacekeepers were kidnapped by the Serbs and publicly humiliated. The resulting news footage prompted multiple blowups from Clinton in which he would visibly shake and express frustrations across the board: with the Serbs, the rules of the UN, his allies, and the situation at large.[lxvii] At one meeting he sharply told Lake that "[W]e've got no clear mission, no one's in control of events".[lxviii] After the fall of Srebrenica in July, Clinton erupted in rage to advisors Berger and Soderberg: "This can't continue. We have to seize control of this."[lxix] At

breakfast days later Clinton recognized that their passive policy "is doing enormous damage to the United States and (…) it can only get worse down the road".[lxx]

Facilitating the withdrawal of UN forces without launching an attack would damage the already suffering credibility of NATO. The UN peacekeeping force UNPROFOR – a joint mission of the United Nations Security Council and NATO – had already established a reputation as a political tool for European powers in order to avoid decisive action against the Serbs.[lxxi] It lacked adequate firepower and had a narrow mandate under which to use force.[lxxii] The mission experienced three distinct failures that weakened NATO's credibility.[lxxiii] First a series of 'pinprick' attacks intended to "send a message" about NATO capabilities targeted obsolete military vehicles and minorly damaged inconsequential infrastructure while deliberately avoiding Serbian warplanes.[lxxiv] The attacks were viewed as absurd and intensified questions surrounding NATO's legitimacy.[lxxv] Second, in the May 1995 hostage situation, UNPROFOR was forced to negotiate the release of its soldiers. Diplomat Richard Holbrooke later recalled the broadcasts on television where "the world's greatest powers [were] brought to their knees by (…) thugs.".[lxxvi] In a third failure, UNPROFOR troops in eastern Bosnia abandoned their safe areas in an effort to reconsolidate.[lxxvii] The Bosnian Serb army overran those areas and committed genocide against the local population.[lxxviii] Only one NATO attack was carried out in response, destroying a singular piece of artillery.[lxxix] With Clinton committed to NATO plan 40-104, the US would soon send 20,000 US troops to a series of risky night-time withdrawal operations that were likely to generate casualties.[lxxx] Deploying troops solely to cover the UN retreat was letting the US stand witness to a failure.[lxxxi] Holbrooke thought that the plan made no sense.[lxxxii] Christopher echoed that it

would be a disaster.[lxxxiii] The State and Defense departments characterized it as a nightmare in and of itself.[lxxxiv] Gore echoed the sentiment, underscoring that NATO looked weak and as the senior partner in NATO, so did the United States.[lxxxv]

The conflict in Bosnia also delayed Clinton's goal of NATO enlargement. His administration coined the term "Democratic Enlargement" to capture their foreign policy agenda of encouraging democracy across the globe and containing dictatorial regimes.[lxxxvi] Clinton decided that NATO could be repurposed to enact this plan: the alliance would offer membership to the new free market democracies of Central and Eastern Europe, bolstering security in Europe and the United States' win in the Cold War.[lxxxvii] In December 1994 NATO ministers initiated a study of potential ways to increase membership, aiming to complete the study in 1995.[lxxxviii] However as the Bosnian crisis worsened it spawned institutional conflicts between NATO and the UN which stalled the negotiations driving the enlargement process.[lxxxix] Additionally officials feared that NATO expansion might cause Russia to react adversely and end its cooperation in Bosnia.[xc] As violence intensified plans for enlargement were postponed.[xci]

Leading up to his adoption of the Endgame Strategy, Clinton characterized Bosnia as a test of American power. At a July 17th meeting Lake present his finalized Endgame Strategy in an "out of character" change from the administration's pattern of day-by-day reactionary policy.[xcii] This long-term mindset was particularly notable because it drew discussion away from the ongoing humanitarian crisis in Srebrenica.[xciii] Clinton spoke resolutely of his commitment to strategic change: "[W]e're in the worst possible situation (…) Our position is unsustainable, it's killing the U.S. position of strength in the world".[xciv] As Clinton left the

room Albright noted that “we have to look at this issue beyond Bosnia (…) I’m glad the president sees this in terms of American power in the world”.[xcv] Lake, Clinton’s strategic architect, agreed: “[T]his is larger than Bosnia. Bosnia has become and is the symbol of U.S. foreign policy” The following day Gore told Clinton that in his view “Acquiescence is not an option”.[xcvi] Clinton agreed that “The situation underscores the need for robust airpower being authorized (…) The United States can’t be a punching bag in the world anymore”.[xcvii]

Clinton was frustrated that international institutions were restricting US leadership and ultimately causing failure in the conflict. Under Clinton’s early non-interventionist policy of containment, peacekeeping responsibilities fell on the UN[xcviii] and the United States restricted its activity to operate within the NATO alliance.[xcix] While this insulated Clinton from full responsibility he began to feel a prisoner of these institutions.[c] Clinton was enraged at the United Nations for putting troops on the ground under “crazy” rules of engagement that endangered the troops’ safety.[ci] NATO was not acting aggressively to protect the UNPROFOR troops.[cii] The UN arms embargo created further difficulties for the president: If the US broke mandate and lifted the embargo then Russia would likely do the same to help the Serbs while the other European nations might abide by the resolution. The Serbs would then overrun the Muslim population and force a withdrawal of British and French UNPROFOR troops.[ciii] Clinton was also frustrated that the UN was barring the US from discussion with the Serbs since they were internationally indicted as war criminals[civ]. Clinton believed such discussion was necessary to reach a diplomatic solution.[cv]

The absence of American power left Clinton rightfully concerned that a European country would assert leadership. Although uncertain of his plans Clinton did not want

another nation to “take the steering wheel” in Bosnia.[cvi] Newly elected French president Jacques Chirac would attempt to do exactly this in the coming months, earning a reputation for blunt discussion and fast action.[cvii] He chastised French commanders for their “cowardice” in Bosnia and ordered they retaliate when attacked.[cviii] He persuaded the British Prime Minister to join him in sending 10,000 extra troops to protect the UN forces.[cix] He scolded the Greek prime minister who sought to rationalize the behavior of the Serbs.[cx] Chirac called the White House in spring 1995 demanding answers for Clinton’s vacillating comments on American commitments in Bosnia. As Clinton attempted to explain, Chirac interrupted in English: “Bill, this is a time when we have to be tough” he counseled.[cxi] Clinton was not appreciative.[cxii] After the fall of Srebrenica, Clinton called Chirac to discuss their options.[cxiii] Chirac suggested a joint air and ground invasion to recapture the city.[cxiv] Clinton told his advisors that he was “getting increasingly squeezed” by Chirac and his outrageous suggestions. [cxv] The advisors noted that Clinton spoke as if Chirac was his competition.[cxvi]

Finally, continuing a non-interventionist policy would strain US relationships with NATO allies who were bearing the war’s burden. The UNPROFOR troops deployed in Bosnia – facing stringent rules of engagement and suffering terrible abuse – were comprised of soldiers from the major European powers[cxvii] and did not include any from the United States.[cxviii] In summer 1995 there was a serious congressional effort to lift the arms embargo on Bosnia to pressure the Serbs without direct intervention. If this occurred, Russia would likely begin supplying arms to the Serbs, endangering the majority French and British UNPROFOR troops. This strained relations with Britain and France, who planned to withdraw their troops in the event the embargo was lifted.[cxix] Additionally several disagreements over

NATO policies accumulated over time, leaving intra-alliance relations at their lowest point since the 1960s.[cxx] As he debated intervention in May 1995, Clinton told Lake that "We have obligations to our NATO allies, and I do not believe we can leave them in the lurch".[cxxi]

Conclusion

Clinton intervened in Bosnia to protect US leadership on the global stage and safeguard alliances. In order to maintain NATO's viability Clinton followed through on his commitment to deploy troops to Bosnia. He decided that facilitating the UNPROFOR withdrawal without confronting the Serbs would bring into question NATO's efficacy. Furthermore, increasing US commitment to the war would both appease NATO allies who were bearing the war's burden and assert dominance over the rising influence of France. As international institutions were limiting US control and causing Clinton frustration, the decisive military intervention brought the US back to a position of global leadership. Clinton's campaign in Bosnia was a military victory that asserted US dominance and defined a new purpose for NATO in the post-Cold War Era. His gambit – initiating a potentially bloody war to secure US global positioning – succeeded with a limited loss of American life. This positive result meant that neither Clinton nor his successors witnessed the counterfactual: What if the mission failed? Thus it became easier to draw overconfidence in America's ability to make change overseas and establish lasting peace. This confidence would prove fateful in the coming years.

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